

Each platform runs on the same basic idea — predict what will keep you watching, then show more of it — but the specific signals differ. Here's a platform-by-platform breakdown, useful for your segment:

TikTok

No two users see the same "For You Page" — it's built entirely from personalized recommendations rather than a follow list. TikTok's For You page shows a mix where 70-80% of content typically comes from accounts you don't follow, meaning any video has a chance to go viral regardless of the creator's follower count.

The ranking leans heavily on watch behavior: TikTok's own Transparency Center confirms the algorithm tracks whether you finish, like, share, or skip a video, and explicitly weighs a strong indicator like finishing a long video more heavily than a weak one like a quick like. In 2026 specifically, the platform raised the bar for completion rate and now weights shares and saves far above likes. It also analyzes the content itself — using natural language processing and computer vision to scan captions, hashtags, spoken words, text overlays, and audio, then matching content to interested audiences.

Instagram

Instagram isn't one algorithm — it's several. Feed, Explore, Reels, and Stories each use different ranking logic, input signals, and distribution rules — which is why the same post can reach thousands via Reels but barely show in the main Feed. The Feed leans on relationship signals because it's built to show content from accounts you already follow, while Explore prioritizes content interest and popularity for discovery, and Reels weighs watch time and share rate most heavily since Instagram is competing with TikTok for attention.

For Reels specifically, sends via direct message are the single most heavily weighted distribution signal, and more broadly Instagram's head, Adam Mosseri, has confirmed the three ranking factors that matter most are watch time, likes per reach, and sends per reach.

YouTube Shorts

YouTube treats Shorts differently from long-form video. With long-form, viewers actively choose what to watch; with Shorts, people are swiping through a feed and discovering content passively — so the viewed-vs-swiped-away ratio becomes the number one metric. If people bail in the first second or two, the video effectively dies in distribution.

YouTube also tests content in stages before wide release: a Short is tested with a small audience, and if it engages well and satisfaction ratings are high, it gets pushed to a broader audience — while long-form videos that flop in the first 48 hours rarely recover. Notably, Shorts and long-form now run on more separated algorithms than before, so a Short doesn't automatically pull viewers into your long-form content the way it used to — the funnel still works, it's just not automatic.

X (Twitter)

X runs two main feeds. The "Following" feed is strictly chronological, showing only accounts you follow in time order with no algorithmic ranking, while the "For You" feed is the recommendation engine — surfacing posts from accounts you don't follow, trending content, and algorithmically boosted posts. Crucially, X defaults every user to the algorithmic "For You" feed now, even those who previously chose "Following" as their default.

Two details worth mentioning on air: replies matter more than likes — conversation quality is now prioritized over raw engagement, with replies reportedly weighted around 27 times more heavily than likes, and the first 30 minutes of engagement velocity is critical for how far a post spreads. Also, the platform actively penalizes posts containing outside links — bare link posts can be suppressed by up to 80%, because X wants to keep people on X rather than sending them elsewhere.

The common thread across all four

Despite different mechanics, every platform converges on the same underlying logic:

1. **Watch time / completion beats simple likes** — finishing content is the strongest signal everywhere.

2. **Non-follower discovery is now the default**, not just following accounts you chose — meaning a stranger's opinion can dominate your feed more than the people you deliberately follow.
3. **Fast, early reaction wins** — the first minutes/hours after posting largely determine whether something spreads, which rewards content that triggers an instant, strong reaction (outrage, shock, humor) over something that needs time to process.

That last point is your bridge back into the misinformation segment — it's the *same* mechanism across all four platforms that makes emotionally charged, unverified claims outperform calm, accurate ones.

Want me to fold this platform breakdown into the write-up document as an added section, or turn it into a quick visual comparison chart for the show?

Here's a practical playbook for making this land with a live audience, plus a clear "why should I care" list for listeners.

Making the Session Engaging

1. Open with a gut-punch hook, not a definition. Don't start with "algorithms are computer programs that..." Start with something people feel: *"Right now, someone in your family group chat believes something is 100% true — and you believe the opposite is 100% true. You're both right, according to your own phone."* That's a stronger opener than any technical explanation.

2. Do the live demo early — it's your strongest visual proof. Have two phones on set (yours and a producer's, or two audience members') logged into the same platform. Search the exact same term live on air and show the different results side by side. Nothing convinces people like watching it happen in real time instead of being told about it.

3. Play "Fact or Feed" as a mid-show reset. Every 8–10 minutes of talk, people's attention drops. Break it up with the guessing game using real Ghanaian viral claims/screenshots. Make the host guess wrong on purpose at least once — it humanizes the topic and shows "even I get fooled by this."

4. Use hyper-local examples, not generic ones. Generic "misinformation exists" talk is forgettable. Naming an actual fake-cure rumor, a doctored political clip, or a WhatsApp panic that circulated in Ghana makes people go "oh, I remember that one" — recognition creates engagement.

5. Bring the audience into the demo. Ask listeners/viewers to screenshot their own "For You" page or search results and send them in during the show (via WhatsApp, SMS, social). Read a few out live. It turns a lecture into a shared discovery.

6. Give it a physical or visual metaphor. Something like: "Imagine two people standing in the same room, but one is wearing red glasses and one is wearing blue glasses — they'll describe the same room completely differently." Concrete images stick far longer than abstract explanations of ranking signals.

7. Use a countdown or checklist moment as a takeaway ritual. Right before you go to break or end the segment, do a fast-paced "3 things to check before you share" moment — quick, punchy, repeatable. This is the part people will actually remember and use.

8. End with a personal challenge, not just information. Instead of "be careful out there," give a specific dare: "*Tonight, follow one account you disagree with. Just one. See what happens to your feed in a week.*" A call-to-action beats a summary.

9. Let some tension breathe. Don't rush to resolve every question with a tidy answer. A brief "...and honestly, that's a genuinely hard problem, even for the platforms" moment builds credibility — it doesn't feel like a lecture, it feels like an honest conversation.

Benefits to Listeners

Practical / immediate:

- They walk away with a concrete 5-second habit (pause before sharing) that actually reduces their chances of spreading — or falling for — a lie.
- They get real tools (reverse image search, cross-checking outlets) they can use the next time a "breaking news" screenshot lands in their family group.

Protective:

- Less vulnerability to fake health cures that could cost them money or, worse, delay real treatment.
- Less likely to be manipulated by doctored political content, especially heading into election-adjacent news cycles.
- Better equipped to protect older relatives who trust WhatsApp forwards from familiar contacts.

Relational:

- Understanding that arguments with friends/family over "facts" are often really just two different algorithm-fed realities colliding — this can genuinely defuse tension rather than escalate it.
- A shared vocabulary ("that's just your feed," "echo chamber," "engagement bait") that makes future conversations about misinformation easier to have.

Long-term / mindset:

- Listeners stop feeling like passive victims of "the algorithm" and start seeing themselves as active participants who can retrain what they see.
- Builds general media literacy that transfers beyond social media — into how they read news, ads, and even political messaging.
- Especially for younger viewers: a healthier relationship with comparison culture and self-esteem, by understanding *why* their feed shows idealized content and that it's engineered, not organic reality.

Want me to turn the "engagement playbook" and "listener benefits" into a one-page cue-card version you can glance at while hosting — timed against your segment structure (demo, game, checklist, CTA)?

Going viral isn't luck or magic — it's a mechanical process the algorithm runs on every post, testing whether it's worth pushing wider. Good segment material because you can demystify it in a few clear steps.

The mechanics: how a post actually "goes viral"

1. It starts with a small test audience. When a new video is published, the algorithm shows it to a small initial group, typically just a few hundred people, then measures how that group responds before deciding anything else.

2. It spreads in waves, not one big jump. If that first small audience engages well, the platform pushes the video to a larger group. If that group also responds strongly, distribution expands again — each wave bigger than the last, and this cascading effect is what actually produces viral reach. It's not "the algorithm decided this is viral" — it's dozens of small pass/fail tests in a row.

3. The first few seconds decide almost everything. The first three seconds of a piece of content are roughly 80% of what determines whether it goes viral — content that fails to hold the viewer in that window simply doesn't get opened up to a wider audience. This is why hooks matter so much more than production quality.

4. Shares and saves matter more than likes. Shares carry particularly heavy weight because they signal the viewer found the content valuable enough to actively send to someone else, and comments — especially longer ones — suggest the content provoked a genuine reaction. A like is passive; a share is a vote.

5. There's a literal tipping point. The tipping point is the moment viral growth becomes self-sustaining, occurring when the "viral coefficient" — essentially, how many new viewers each existing viewer brings in — consistently stays above 1. Below that point, growth is slow and linear. Cross it, and growth becomes exponential almost on its own.

6. Emotion is the fuel, not a side effect. Emotional triggers tap directly into human psychology to encourage sharing, with humor, fear, anger, and inspiration being the most common ones used. This is your direct link back to the misinformation half of your segment — the same mechanic that makes a funny dance trend go viral is what makes a fake health scare go viral.

How this connects back to your main segment topic

This is actually a great "aha" moment for viewers: **going viral and misinformation spreading are the exact same mechanism.** A post doesn't go viral *because* it's true or false — it goes viral because it passes the algorithm's engagement tests. A fake cure and a genuinely helpful health tip are judged by the identical yardstick: does this make people react fast and hard?

You could frame it on air as:

"Going viral has nothing to do with being right. It has to do with being reactive. That's the uncomfortable truth behind every fake story that outran the true one."

One nuance worth mentioning (adds credibility)

Not everything that spreads needs an algorithm's help at all. Content with the right resonance can theoretically spread eventually regardless of initial push — the algorithm and network effects mostly determine the speed and probability of it happening, not whether it happens at all. That's a good "even organic word-of-mouth follows patterns" aside if you want to sound balanced rather than purely anti-algorithm.

Want this folded into the write-up as a new section ("How Something Goes Viral — and Why That's the Same Mechanism Behind Misinformation"), or kept as standalone host notes?

Here's fresh, high-value material you haven't covered yet — good for extending the segment or fielding audience questions.

1. AI Deepfakes — the next escalation of this exact problem

This is the most urgent addition, since it takes everything you've already covered and makes it worse.

Deepfakes have crossed a critical threshold in 2026 — they've eliminated the earlier tell-tale glitches and are now accessible to anyone with a smartphone. Multiple independent studies back this up: a 2025 study in the Journal of Creative Communications found that people struggle to identify deepfake videos and that their opinions are influenced by this disinformation, and a separate pre-registered experiment with 210 participants confirmed that people do not reliably detect deepfakes at all.

Worth noting for your audience: just knowing deepfakes exist can make people doubt things that are actually true — the damage isn't only "people believe fake things," it's also "people stop trusting real things." That's a powerful point to make on air — the threat isn't only being fooled, it's losing the ability to trust anything.

2. Local Ghanaian fact-checking resources — give your audience actual

tools

This is your strongest practical add. Right now your checklist says "check a credible outlet" — you can now name exactly who to check:

- **Dubawa Ghana** — launched in Ghana to empower the public with tools for informed, rational decision-making in an era of rising "information disorder."
- **GhanaFact and Fact-Check Ghana** — Ghanaian fact-checking organizations that have documented how certain false claims recirculate across the region for over a decade, resurfacing in new forms every few years.
- **The Ghana Fact-Checking Coalition** — formed by the Media Foundation for West Africa, Dubawa, FactSpace West Africa, and other civil society groups specifically to mount a joint, coordinated response to misinformation and disinformation around Ghana's elections.

A great concrete example for your "Fact or Feed" game: GhanaFact identified a false claim circulating in June 2025 that the government intended to introduce mandatory DNA testing starting January 2026 — and researchers note these kinds of falsehoods often lack specific dates, which makes them feel perpetually relevant, and are frequently falsely attributed to authoritative figures to lend them credibility. That's a real, recent, nameable Ghanaian example you can put on screen.

3. There's a policy conversation happening right now — good for a "what should change" segment

Ghanaian media stakeholders, including the Media Foundation for West Africa and the National Peace Council, have called for a shift from reactive content moderation to prevention — including delayed posting for flagged content pending human review, graduated penalties for repeat offenders, and a proposed Digital Media Integrity Bill that would define online misinformation and prescribe penalties for deliberate falsehoods. This gives you a natural closing question for guests: "*Should Ghana have a law like this?*" — a genuinely open, debatable question rather than a lecture point.

4. The "attention economy" angle — why this isn't an accident

Useful if you want to go slightly deeper on *why* platforms are built this way: algorithms reward engagement financially, and the incentive structures of major platforms mean outrage delivers faster because it triggers immediate sharing before fact-checking can even occur. This reframes the whole topic from "some people are gullible" to "the system is built to make everyone vulnerable" — a more empathetic, less finger-pointing frame that plays better on air.

5. A sharper caution about AI chatbots and "trusted" tools

Worth a mention if you want to feel current: Some disinformation efforts now specifically target AI chatbots through data-poisoning attacks designed to spread misleading information — meaning even asking an AI assistant to "fact-check" something isn't automatically safe anymore. Good reminder that no single tool is a silver bullet — verification is a habit, not a gadget.

How I'd slot these in

- **Deepfakes (#1)** → new host question near the top: *"Is it getting harder to trust your own eyes?"*
- **Local fact-checkers (#2)** → fold directly into your existing checklist segment — naming Dubawa/GhanaFact by name gives viewers something to actually do tonight.
- **DNA testing rumor (#2)** → perfect as one of your "Fact or Feed" round examples.
- **Policy question (#3)** → strong closing debate question for a guest or call-in segment.
- **Attention economy (#4)** → good pivot line right before your "platforms' responsibility" host question.

Want me to fold all of this into the write-up document as new sections, or keep it as a separate "extra material" cue sheet you can pull from live if time allows?

